Setting Up Telegram and BotFather

Complete this guide before the build session on 23 Sept. The 60-minute build clock starts the moment you open your laptop in class - Telegram, your bot, and your API keys must be ready before you walk in.

01 Install Telegram

First install Telegram on your phone and create an account.

If you already have Telegram installed on your phone, skip to Section 02.

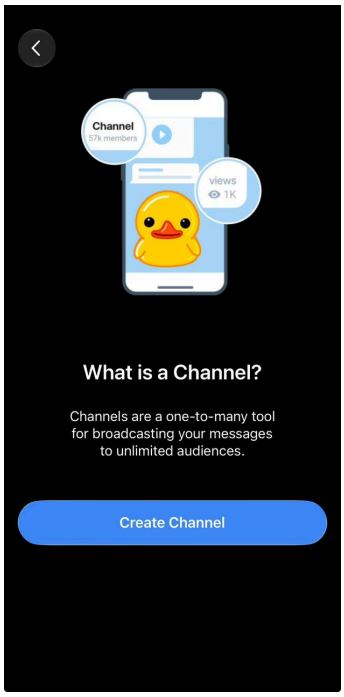
02 Create Your Capture Channel

In Case 1, Meera sends notes to a private Telegram channel she created for herself. You will create the same thing - a private channel that only you and your bot can access. This is the trigger point of your pipeline.

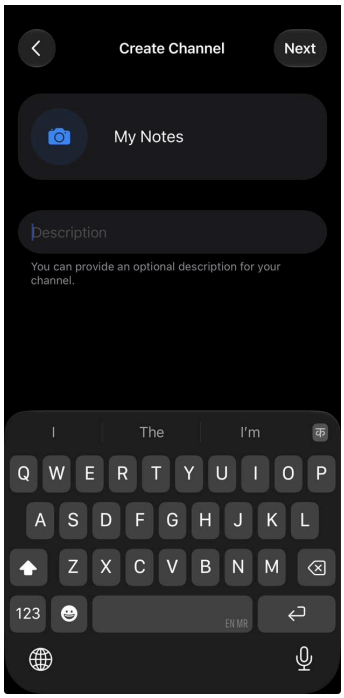
> **NOTE:** A channel is different from a group chat. A channel is broadcast-only - only admins can post. This is what you want. You will post notes; the bot will read them.

Step 1 On iPhone: tap the compose icon (pencil) at the top right of the chat list. On Android: tap the pencil icon at the bottom right.

Step 2 Select New Channel from the menu.

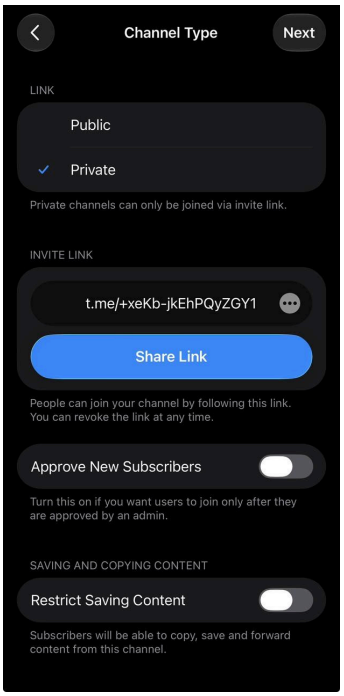


Step 3 Give your channel a name. Something like "My Notes" or "Content Captures" works. The name is only visible to you and your bot. Tap Next.



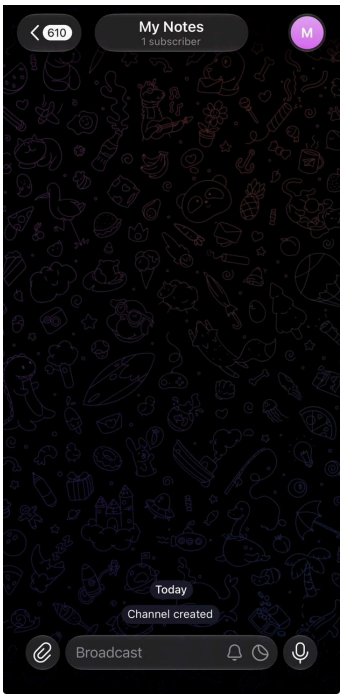
Step 4 When asked about channel type, select Private. Tap Next.

A private channel cannot be found by search and has no public link. This is correct for our use case.



Step 5 Skip adding subscribers for now. Tap Skip or click on Next to continue.

Step 6 Your channel is created. You will see it appear in your chat list and open automatically.

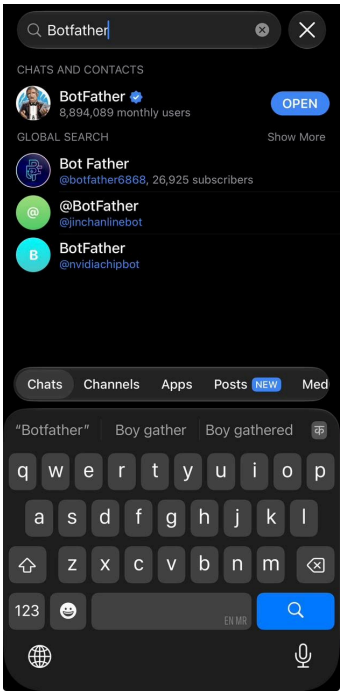


TIP Keep this channel open. You will return to it in Section 04 to add your bot as an administrator.

03 Create a Bot with BotFather

BotFather is Telegram's official bot for creating and managing other bots. It is a verified Telegram account, not a third-party service. All bot creation happens through a conversation with BotFather inside the Telegram app.

Step 1 In Telegram, tap the search icon (magnifying glass) and type "BotFather".



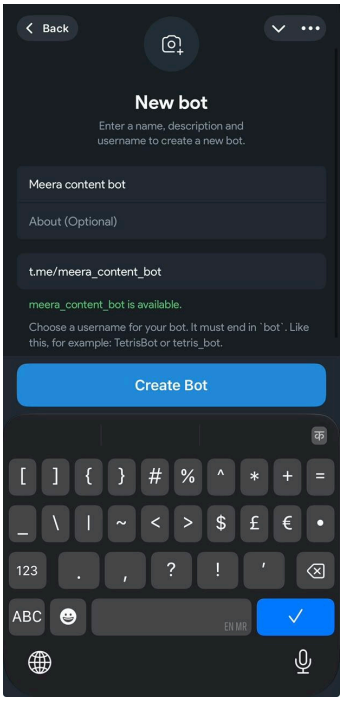
Step 2 Select the result with the verified checkmark and the username @BotFather. Do not tap any result without the checkmark.

Step 3 Tap Start at the bottom of the screen OR type /start and send it OR click on Create a New Bot.

BotFather will usually reply with a list of available commands.

Step 4 Type /newbot and send it.

Step 5 BotFather will ask for a name for your bot. This is the display name — it can be anything. For example: Skinstinct Content Bot. Type it and send.



Step 6 BotFather will then ask for a username. The username must be unique across all of Telegram and must end in the word "bot". For example: skinstinct_content_bot. Type it and send.

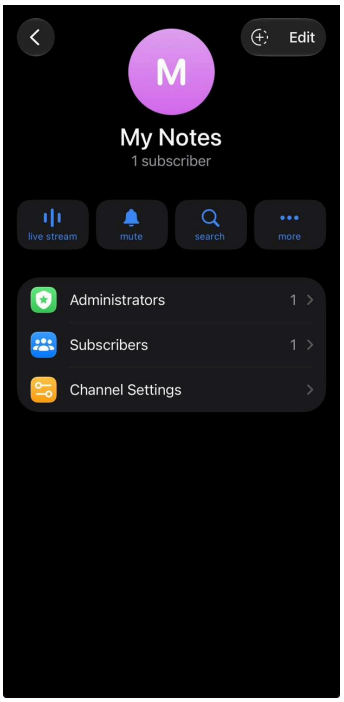
If the username is taken, BotFather will say so and ask you to try another. Add numbers or underscores until it accepts.

Step 7 BotFather will reply with a confirmation message. This message contains your Bot Token - a long string of characters that looks like: 7412938475:AAGdkqOPmL9eR3n_Kk2xV8wJ4uZtNcBo1pY

04 Add Your Bot to the Channel

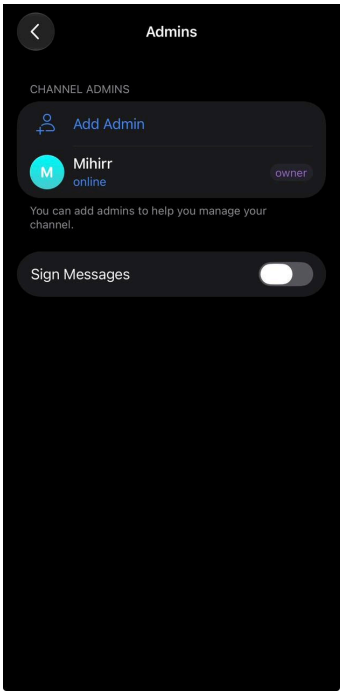
Your bot needs to be an administrator of your capture channel so it can read messages posted there. Without this step, your bot cannot see anything you send to the channel.

Step 1 Go to your capture channel (the one you created in Section 02). Tap the channel name at the top to open the channel info.



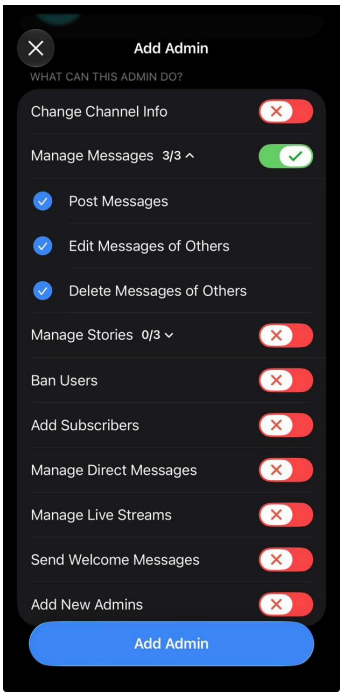
Step 2 Scroll down and tap Administrators.

Step 3 Tap Add Administrator.



Step 4 Search for your bot using the username you created in Section 04 (e.g. @skinstinct_content_bot). Select it from the results.

Step 5 A permissions screen will appear. The only permission your bot needs is Post Messages. You can leave all other permissions toggled off.



Step 6 Tap Save. Your bot now appears in the Administrators list.

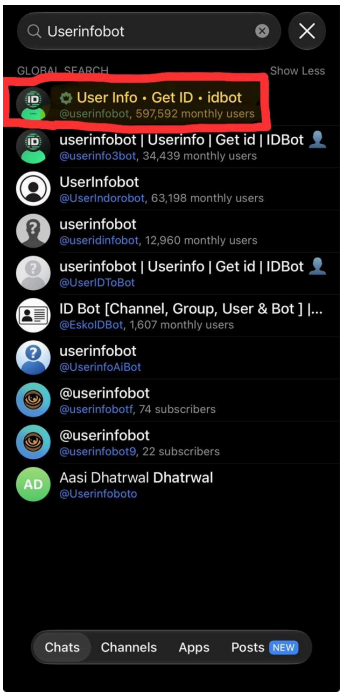
> **NOTE** Your bot is now a silent admin in the channel. It cannot post by itself - it can only listen. Posting is always Meera's action.

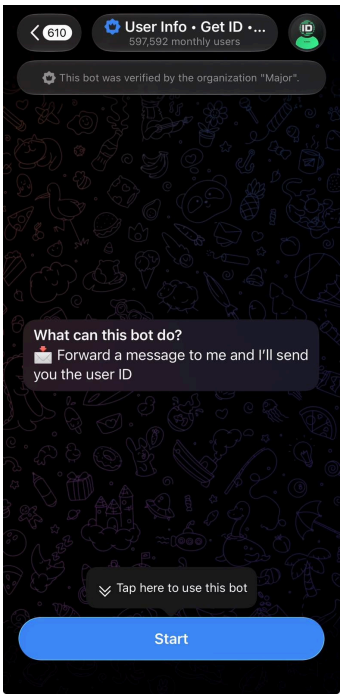
05 Get Your Channel's Chat ID

Your code needs to know which Telegram channel to listen to. Each channel has a unique Chat ID - a negative number that your bot uses to identify the source of incoming messages. You need to find this number and save it in a document.

> **NOTE** Channel Chat IDs are always negative numbers starting with -100. A regular user or group chat has a positive ID. If you get a positive number, you have the wrong ID.

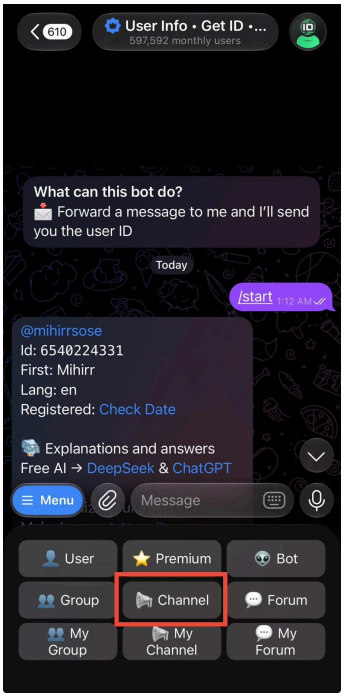
Step 1 In Telegram, search for the bot @userinfobot and start a conversation with it.

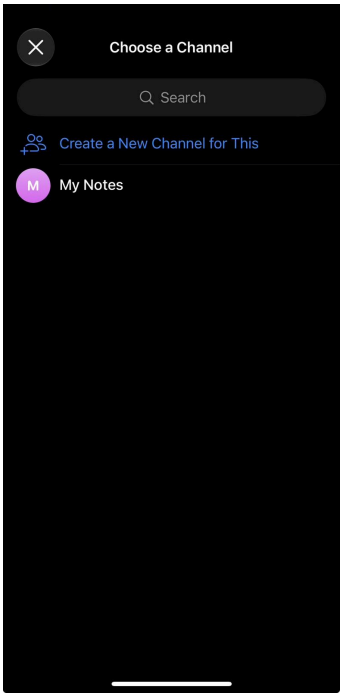


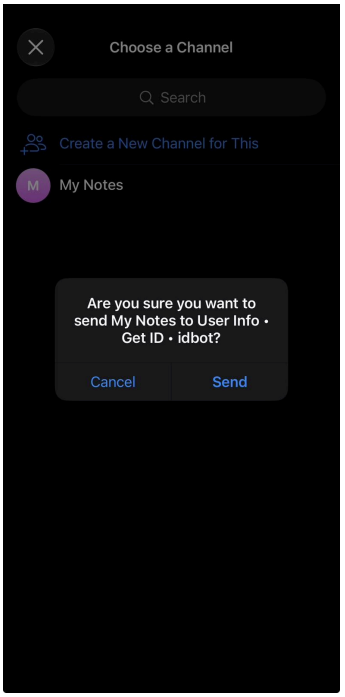


Step 2 Go to your capture channel. Forward any message from the channel to @userinfobot.

If the channel is empty, send yourself a test message first — type anything, like "test" — then forward that message to @userinfobot.







Step 3 @userinfobot will reply with information about the forwarded message, including a field labelled "Forwarded from". The number next to it is your channel's Chat ID.

Step 4 Copy the Chat ID number (including the minus sign).

07 Pre-Session Checklist

Confirm each item before arriving on 23 Sept. If any item is incomplete, work through the relevant section again or contact the session coordinator.

- ☐ Telegram installed on my phone
  Section 01
- ☐ Telegram account created and verified
  Section 01
- ☐ Private capture channel created
  Section 02 — name does not matter, must be Private
- ☐ Bot created via @BotFather with a confirmed username
  Section 03
- ☐ Bot added as Administrator to my capture channel (Post Messages only)
  Section 04
- ☐ Chat ID retrieved via @userinfobot and saved as TELEGRAM_CHAT_ID
  Section 05 — must be a negative number starting with -100